

UAC during install and did not turn it on when it finished. We didn't even notice it at first because the suite gives you no notification that it is doing that. Diametrically opposite to NetProtect is EScan, which completely wrests control of the PC from the user. It automatically launches Windows update and also forces a secure login, where you have to enter your username and password to access your PC. Speaking of quirks, NetProtect also has this weird restriction where it cannot scan more than five individual files or folders at a time. It has no problem scanning four folders containing over 200 files each though, so we can't figure out what the problem is.

Performance

The malware detection rate has already been mentioned in the table so we won't really talk about it too much. A surprising point to note was that Norton 360 had the worst detection rate at a measly 10 percent, we were so taken aback by the score that we ran the malware scan again just to be sure.

The rest of the security suites managed an average detection rate of about 50 percent. Don't be alarmed, all the security suites haven't suddenly become defunct, it's just that we used a selection of malware over a period of 15 days, and the most recent ones may not even have a patch yet.

Coming to the payload tests, most of the suites couldn't detect the tier 1 payloads. Avast in particular made full use of its file-ranking system to assist in detection. While its AV engine failed to detect anything wrong with the downloads, the file-rating system



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flagged the file as an unrated one and recommended that the connection be terminated. What was disappointing was that if the file does get through, Avast allows it to run for about 15 seconds, in which time it waits for a user response, this was more than enough time for us to hack into the system using our payload.

AVG's firewall also managed to detect the files, but recommended that they be allowed through. K7 detected the incoming packet from our server but could not detect the payloads or the attempt by the payload to connect to the server. The rest of the responses can be seen in the table (refer to "How we tested" for explanations on payloads). Those which got a score of zero allowed all payloads through with absolutely no hindrance from the security suite being tested.

The malware tests were quite straightforward, again, the number of websites blocked is shown in the table. We did notice something interesting where the browser itself (Google Chrome in our case), was blocking most of the sites and we had to manually force the sites to open to test the security

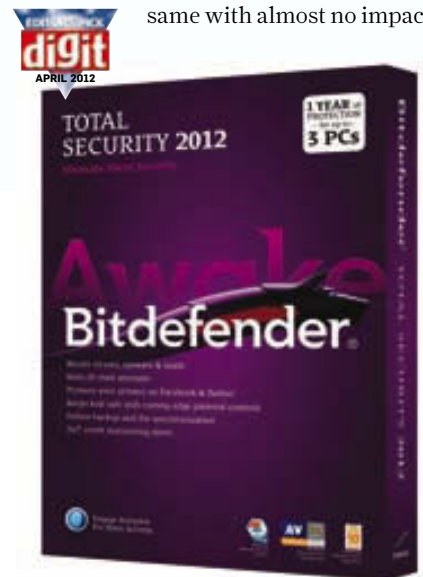
suites. Surprisingly, ZoneAlarm, always known for its good firewall, was the worst of the lot.

Productivity

Most of the security suites had a negligible impact in terms of productivity. The K7 and Panda suites were terrible when it came to file transfers (at default settings), with both suites taking an astonishing 48 minutes and 5 minutes respectively

to transfer our 2GB bundle of assorted files. The ideal time should have been under a minute. Obviously, this extended transfer time is because the AV engine was scanning the files while writing to the disk. This is expected from a security suite but at 48 minutes (an average of around 700KB/s), this is way too much time spent on scanning the files, especially when other suites can do this faster and still have a higher detection rate.

Norton 360 had a distinct impact on the system even in idle mode (Peacekeeper benchmark) which can easily be put down to the fact that the engine was scanning all incoming and outgoing data, this is alright for security, but when you consider that Bitdefender does the same with almost no impact,



Bitdefender Total Security 2012

Norton 360 seems to be a tad heavy on the system. While Kaspersky impacts the system, you have the option to set resource management within the engine itself. Since we were testing at default values, we did not fiddle with this setting and anyway, system impact during scan was given a minimal weightage in scoring.

Winners

Best Performer

Going by pure performance numbers and disregarding every other aspect, this title goes to BullGuard Internet Security Suite 12. It was a very close



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